

Auditing in Microsoft Purview: Standard vs Premium

Understanding
retention, insights,
and compliance
readiness



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Why Auditing Matters

- Organizations need **visibility** into user and admin activity
- Supports **compliance, investigations, and incident response**
- Integrated into the **Microsoft 365 Purview Compliance Portal**

+ • Audit ◦ Standard (Included with E3 / Business Premium)

- Enabled **by default** in Purview
- Thousands of searchable audit events
- Audit search tool + **PowerShell (Search-UnifiedAuditLog)**
- Export logs to CSV for analysis
- Integration with **Office 365 Management API**
- **90-day retention** of audit logs

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Audit Premium (Requires E5 / Compliance Add-on)

- **Retention policies** → extend logs up to **10 years**
- **Intelligent insights** → forensic investigations, anomaly detection
- Deeper auditing for **Exchange & SharePoint**
- **Higher bandwidth** → faster, larger-scale log searches
- 1-year retention by default, expandable with policies

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Licensing Snapshot

- **E3 / Business Premium** → Audit Standard
- **E5 / Compliance Add-On** → Audit Premium
- Decision depends on:
 - Compliance requirements (90 days vs 10 years)
 - Forensics & investigation needs
 - Performance expectations

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Lab/Industry Example

- In a lab setup, I compared Standard vs Premium auditing. With E3, I could search 90 days of log events and export results. With E5, I extended retention policies for up to 10 years and tested intelligent insights for investigation scenarios. This highlights how licensing directly impacts audit depth and compliance readiness.

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Key Takeaways

- Standard auditing is **sufficient for most organizations** (90 days)
- Premium auditing is **critical for regulated industries** (long retention, insights)
- Always align audit capabilities with **licensing strategy + compliance needs**